wishing to travel to Pakistan for training. For Westerners, especially during the 1990s, it was much easier.

One JuD member close to Lashkar's leaders admitted the group has long had a policy of training Westerners.[144] Some of those trainees have gone on to fight with Lashkar in Indian-administered Kashmir. Augmenting its ranks with large numbers of Western would-be jihadis was never a reasonable strategy, however, nor one the group seems to have considered seriously. Instead, recruiting and training Westerners appears to have served four main purposes: first, it enabled the group to develop a transnational network, which it used primarily for logistical and support purposes; second, it promoted Lashkar's reputation as an organization with international reach and appeal; third it allowed the group to build its brand among the Kashmiri diaspora who contributed large amounts of money to the groups fighting in Indian-administered Kashmir; and fourth it was a means of promoting the concept of jihad and propagating Lashkar's version of Ahl-e-Hadith Islam. Historically, the majority of its Western trainees and operatives are believed to have come from the diaspora in the United Kingdom, though Americans and Europeans trained with the group as well. Estimates vary as to how many Westerners passed through Lashkar's camps, but it appears that few were actually sent to fight. Some were enlisted as operatives to support the group's activities in the West and many more were indoctrinated with Lashkar's extreme interpretation of jihad.[145]

The group took several steps to recruit Westerners. First, it propagated its views and ideology among diaspora youth when they visited relatives or friends in Pakistan and incited them to jihad in much the same way it did people who lived there. A disproportionate number of British Pakistanis are of Kashmiri descent and hail from the city and environs of Mirpur in Pakistan-administered Kashmir.[146] Because of the influence of the Kashmiri diaspora, most of the jihadi outfits and their above-ground organizations operated offices in Mirpur and proselytizing to visiting youth was common.[147] According to one Metropolitan Police Service source, at the time British Pakistanis with connections to Kotli [also in Pakistan-administered Kashmir] as well as Gujrat and Sialkot [in Punjab province] were also considered to be particularly well-suited to leverage familial connections in order to attain training.[148] To promote its image as a training provider Lashkar also advertised. For example, in 1999 the now-defunct